

XUQIAN MA

ma000092@berkeley.edu • 607-262-3775 • [LinkedIn](#)

RESEARCH FIELDS

Health Economics

EDUCATION

University of California, Berkeley

PhD in Health Policy (Health Economics)

Dissertation: Essays on Preventive Health Behaviors

Berkeley, CA

Expected May 2027

Cornell University

MS in Economics (International and Development Economics)

Ithaca, NY

May 2022

University of Minnesota Twin Cities

BS in Economics (Quantitative Economics and Econometrics)

Minneapolis, MN

May 2020

JOB MARKET PAPER

“Quantitative Reasoning and Vaccine Uptake: Evidence from Influenza and COVID-19 Vaccination”

Measuring quantitative reasoning may help explain differences in vaccine uptake across individuals and over time. I test whether different measures are more strongly associated with vaccine uptake after the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic than before it. Using the Understanding America Study, I examine two candidate measures: quantitative ability, assessed through numerical and financial literacy tests, and choice consistency, measured by how closely incentivized financial choices align with stable preferences. I link these measures to reported influenza vaccination from 2014–2026 and COVID-19 vaccination during the 2021 rollout. Influenza results provide suggestive support: choice consistency becomes more positively associated with uptake after 2020, while quantitative ability shows a similar but statistically insignificant change. During the COVID-19 rollout, quantitative ability is positively associated with uptake in later phases, whereas choice consistency shows no consistent positive association. These findings motivate further research on how standard health surveys can best measure the quantitative reasoning skills relevant to health decisions.

PUBLICATION

Ma, Xuqian, Michelle Layvant, Edward Miguel, Eric Ochieng, Ajay Pillarisetti, and Michael Walker. **“Impacts of contemporaneous air pollution exposure on cognitive performance in Kenya.”** *Journal of Health Economics* (2026): 103166.

REVISE AND RESUBMIT

“Mitigating Cognitive Deficits from Prenatal Air Pollution: Experimental Evidence from a Nutrition Intervention”. Xuqian Ma, Yuhang Pan, Lingling Hou, and Renfu Luo. *Revise and resubmit, Journal of the Association of Environmental and Resource Economists*

WORKING PAPER

“War, Memory, and Mind: The Long-Term Consequences of the Vietnam War”. Xuqian Ma, William H. Dow and Yasuhiko Saito. *In preparation for submission*

PRESENTATIONS

American Society of Health Economists Annual Conference	2026
ESE–RGHI–GHE Workshop on Health Economics in LMICs	2026
Yale Workshop, “New Data, Methods, and Theory: Life-Course Cognitive Inequality”	2026
Population Association of America Annual Meeting	2025
Psychology and Economics of Poverty Convening	2024
Pacific Conference for Development Economics	2024
Asian Workshop on Econometrics and Health Economics	2023
Harvard Spatial Data Lab Webinar on Spatiotemporal Innovation	2023

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Health Economics

Fall 2026

MPH program, Berkeley Public Health; Brent Fulton

Economics of Population Health

Spring 2025, 2026

MPH program, Berkeley Public Health; William H. Dow

Cost-Effectiveness Analysis

Spring 2025, 2026

MPH program, Berkeley Public Health; William H. Dow

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Center for Effective Global Action, UC Berkeley

Berkeley, CA

Graduate Student Researcher; Principal Investigator: Edward Miguel

May 2023–present

Kenya Life Panel Survey

FELLOWSHIPS, GRANTS, AND AWARDS

Preparing Future Faculty UDL Working Group Grant	Summer 2025
Summer Research Fellowship	Summers 2023–2025
Best Poster Award, Population Association of America Annual Meeting	Spring 2025
Shortell/Schaeffer Fellowship	2024–2025
Berkeley Fellowship for Graduate Study	2022–2024
Berkeley Health Policy Department Conference Travel Grant	2023, 2025, 2026
Berkeley Graduate Division Conference Travel Grant	2023, 2026

METHODS AND SOFTWARE

Causal inference; machine learning; GIS and spatial analysis; R, Stata

REFERENCES

William H. Dow Professor, UC Berkeley School of Public Health wdow@berkeley.edu	Edward Miguel Professor, UC Berkeley Department of Economics emiguel@berkeley.edu	Shachar Kariv Professor, UC Berkeley Department of Economics kariv@berkeley.edu
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